

states JAMMU & KASHMIR

■ By Aijaz Hussain in Srinagar

When Ghulam Rasool Padder, of south Kashmir's Larnoo village, about 105 km from Srinagar, reported to the police that his son Abdul Rehman had been missing since December 8 last year, they thought it was just another missing person report and launched a customary investigation. The 35-year-old junior Padder, a carpenter by profession, was carrying his cellphone when he went missing from the summer capital. With help from BSNL, it was traced to the Ganderbal unit of the Special Operations Group (sog) of the police.

Recently, Chief Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad conceded on the floor of the state legislature that in the last two years, there have been 11 custodial deaths, seven custodial disappearances and not less than 20 cases of rape and molestation by the police and other security officials. The State Human Rights Commission (SHRC), however, alleged in its report tabled during the same Assembly session that there were 36 custodial disappearances, 25 cases of harassment and 20 custodial deaths in one year alone. These figures were preceded by definitive cases of custodial murders by officials of the sog.

The skeletons started tumbling out of the closet when it was found that the



KILLERS IN KHAKI

The recent spate of fake encounters in the Valley has sent shock waves among civilians

police had picked up Padder, framing him as a Pakistani militant, Abu Zahid. Along with CRPF men, they had shot him dead in a staged gun battle. A special investigation team headed by Deputy Inspector General (DIG) Farooq Ahmed was constituted to probe the case. As it turned out, Padder was not the only victim of the sog. Four other innocent civilians had met with the same fate. The bodies of all five were exhumed from the catchments of the sog and handed over to their families for burial.

At least seven police officials, including SSP H.R. Parihar and Deputy SP Bahadur Ram, were arrested while

scores were detained for interrogation. The police officers picked up labourers and menial workers, robbed them of their belongings, branded them as foreign militants and killed them in "joint operations" with the army and the CRPF. In all the cases, the sog and the army had filed fake FIRs in the police records and claimed they had recovered rifles and other ammunition from the "slain foreign militants". These murders would fetch the officials cash rewards and promotions.

It is common knowledge that for many years, police officials have been putting away arms seized during

genuine operations for use in such killings. Says DIG Ahmed, "We have been probing the case comprehensively, ranging from conducting DNA tests of the victims to investigating the source of the arms that security forces claim they had found on the dead." What is appalling is that Parihar had escaped action in a similar case and the police even ignored court directions that a murder case be registered against him for the disappearance of Fayaz Ahmed Beig, a photographer at the University of Kashmir, in 1997.

Another arrested police official, constable Farooq Ahmed, who sur-